

Illustration by SIDDHANT JUMDE

GLASSHOUSE

BATTLE FOR BIHU

Although Prime Minister Narendra Modi has in the past promoted and celebrated regional festivals and customs, his recent involvement in a competitive showcasing that happened around the celebration of Rongali Bihu, Assam's prime festival, was accidental. On April 14, Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma published a full-page advertisement in several national newspapers greeting people on the occasion of Rongali Bihu. The ad prominently featured a photograph of Modi wearing a *gamocha*, the traditional Assamese towel. Then, on April 23, Sarma's predecessor and current Union minister Sarbananda Sonowal hosted a Bihu celebration at his official residence in Delhi where Modi was invited as chief guest and where the PM sportingly took to the stage and played the *dhol*. The oneupmanship ensured that Bihu got the endorsement of India's biggest political brand ambassador.

Starstruck Tourists



Maharashtra tourism minister **Aaditya Thackeray** is trying hard to promote the state's tiger sanctuaries as a destination for foreign tourists, but the visitors seem to be only interested in Bollywood and spend their time in the state visiting film sets. In fact, a Vietnam official recently said that the Hindi soap opera *Balika Vadhu*, dubbed in the local language, had become the most watched TV programme in his country. Walter J. Lindner, German ambassador to India and a cinephile, has suggested 10 potential shoot locations in Germany for Indian films. Thackeray is clearly going to need more aggressive marketing to promote tigers, ironically also his party Shiv Sena's symbol.

A GUIDE TO GANDHIGIRI

UK Prime Minister **Boris Johnson**, who was in India recently, was given an unusual gift by the Sabarmati Ashram Trust during his trip to Ahmedabad—a book titled *Guide to London*. Penned by Mahatma Gandhi, the unpublished book contains his suggestions on how to live in the UK capital. However, there may be more than meets the eye to this gift. Johnson had landed in controversy last year after he and his colleagues violated Covid norms during a party hosted at the PM's official residence in London. The book might be the trust's 'subtle' way of communicating Gandhi's emphasis on following rules.





BANDEEP SINGH

FRIEND TURNED FOE

After week-long parleys, poll strategist **Prashant Kishor** declined to join the Congress. While both sides are offering different versions on why they could not work together, some Congress insiders had predicted it. Their cue was Rahul Gandhi's absence from the discussions. Several members of the old guard showed public enthusiasm for Kishor's inclusion, but team Rahul wants the high command to implement his first prescription—sack those above 70. Ironically, the average age of five of the eight members who deliberated on Kishor's proposals was 72. Sonia Gandhi made one final offer to Kishor—win Gujarat with limited power and then take a promotion within the party. He declined. Now that talks have failed between Congress and Kishor, he is left with a new client—Telangana CM K. Chandrashekar Rao. Interestingly, in Telangana, he will face his former colleagues Sunil Kanugulu, who is helping the Congress in the state, and Himanshu Singh, who is working with the BJP. May the best player win.

—Kaushik Deka with Kiran D. Tare